

RISING AIRFARES

Nothing Budget About Airfares

Rising demand, limited capacities, and strategic pricing by airlines have contributed to the surge in air ticket prices

BY RICHA SHARMA

18 | ► **NOT SO LONG** ago, budget airlines were the go-to choice for cost-conscious travellers. Affordable fares made air travel accessible to millions. But today, booking an air ticket—even on a low-cost carrier—feels like a premium experience, at least in terms of pricing. Whether last-minute travel, or pre-planned trips, airfares across budget airlines are soaring, often rivaling full-service carriers.

From Mahakumbh in Prayagraj to the Coldplay music concert in Ahmedabad, and now the approaching summer holidays, spikes in airfares have become the norm rather than the exception. An airline ticket on the Delhi-Prayagraj route, which otherwise costs around ₹5,000, touched to ₹30,000-40,000 during the ongoing Mahakumbh.

The Director General of Civil Aviation's (DGCA's) intervention to check the surge in airfare hasn't made much difference, though the airlines said they flew more aircraft on the route. Rising demand, limited capacities, and strategic pricing by carriers have contributed to the surge in prices, leaving travellers to wonder whether travelling by budget airlines

would truly be affordable again.

Getting flight tickets at reasonable rates if booked three to four months in advance is a thing of the past now. With a rise in the number of people travelling by air, even sale offers by airlines don't lower the ticket prices on high-demand sectors such as metro cities.

COSTLIER VACATIONS

Airfares to Southeast Asian destinations, like Bali, Phuket, and Singapore, and hill stations and beaches in the domestic sector surge during vacations.

"Demand surges as travellers plan their holidays, leading to higher ticket prices, especially for popular tourist destinations. Additionally, factors such as fuel costs, airline capacity, and

₹30,000+

**AIRLINE TICKET ON THE
DELHI-PRAYAGRAJ ROUTE
DURING THE ONGOING
MAHAKUMBH**



TRAVEL FAVOURITES

Airfares to Southeast Asian destinations like Bali, Phuket, and Singapore in the international sector, and hill stations and beaches in the domestic sector see heightened demand during vacations

geopolitical influences can further impact airfare trends," Jatinder Paul, CEO and Co-founder of travel agency Viacation, tells *Business Today*.

Despite new aircraft orders and airport upgrades, increased capacities have not yet translated into lower fares. "Internationally, North America and Europe are seeing modest airfare increases as airline